

CAR-FREE STREETS

Open Streets are Business Incubators, Yet Another Report Shows

Want jobs? Keep out the cars.



By **Gersh Kuntzman**



12:03 AM EST on January 30, 2026



Eyes on the street: Open streets create foot traffic that is good for business.

Want jobs? Keep out the cars.

Yet another report — this time from state Comptroller Tom DiNapoli — reveals that job growth is more robust on most of the city's open streets, with more than 74 percent of the non-school locations adding retail and restaurant jobs.

And at those 200 or so locations, more than 67,200 jobs were created — with nearly a majority of those slots (46 percent) created at the 62 locations that ha

an open street for all five years between 2020 and 2024. Almost 98 percent of those were created in Manhattan and Brooklyn, but that's because those boroughs are more likely to have had open streets from the start of the pandemic through 2024.

"The Open Streets program ... continues to encourage foot traffic to support shopping, dining and other activities in many parts of the city," DiNapoli said in a statement.

The new data won't surprise New Yorkers who have been paying attention to the business-friendly quality of car-free streets. In 2022, the Department of Transportation reported that restaurants and bars on open streets increased their sales by 19 percent above their pre-pandemic baseline while sales dropped by 29 percent at establishments that weren't on car-free corridors.

Two years later, the Department of City Planning reported that open streets have a 12-percent lower vacancy rate than the citywide average.

But the new report adds a few new wrinkles.

For instance, open streets in Manhattan added significantly more retail and restaurant jobs than the rest of the borough, with Brooklyn and the Bronx adding slightly more and Queens on Staten Island open streets actually adding fewer jobs than compared to the rest of those boroughs.

The failure of Queens and Staten Island might simply be because of those boroughs' lower participation numbers across the entire study period, from the dawn of the pandemic to the end of 2024. There were only 62 such locations — "and those were concentrated in Manhattan and Brooklyn," the report stated.

The Job Leaders

Here are the 10 best open streets for job growth between 2020 and 2024.



Neighborhood	Open Street	Start	End	% More jobs
D'town Bkln/Fort Greene	S. Portland Ave.	567	2,865	405.1%
Hudson Yards	Hudson Blvd. East	1,223	3,318	171.3%
Williamsburg/Greenpoint	Graham Ave/Skillman	292	741	153.8%
Williamsburg/Greenpoint	S. First St.	1,294	3,144	142.9%
Lower East Side	Orchard St.	2,081	4,837	132.4%
Williamsburg/Greenpoint	Randolph St.	174	404	132.2%
FiDi/Greenwich Village	Jane St.	775	1,751	125.9%
Harlem	Frederick Douglass Blvd.	258	581	125.2%
Upper West Side	W. 74th St.	379	838	121.0%
Sunset Park	Fifth Ave.	351	754	114.8%

Source: [NYS Comptroller](#) • [Get the data](#) • Created with [Datawrapper](#)

Advocates for reducing the deleterious effect of cars on our city were certainly pleased by the findings.

“This new report validates what we have known for years – –that open streets are an engine for boosting economic vitality, jobs, and community connections,” said Sara Lind, co-executive director of Open Plans. “We encourage lawmakers to take heed from these findings and allocate funds from the city and state budgets to increase and provide support for open streets across New York.”

And a spokesperson for DOT also joined in the fun.

“As [the] report shows, when we design people-centric streets and utilize strategies like open streets, it benefits local businesses and all New Yorkers,” said DOT spokesman Scott Gastel.

Of course, it’s not all peaches and cream.



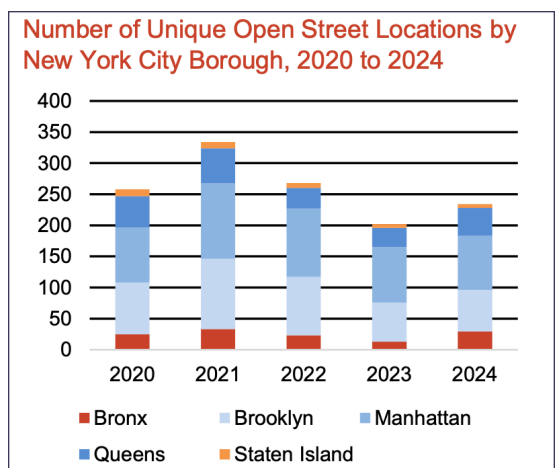
DiNapoli said that the city should do more to mitigate concerns of the volunteer groups or business improvement districts that operate the open streets for the city. Many organizers have complained, for instance, of limited public funding and the failure of NYPD to enforce traffic and parking rules.

Crunching 311 data, DiNapoli's office discovered that illegal parking was a major concern, with complaints rising by 178 percent on open streets between 2020 and 2024.

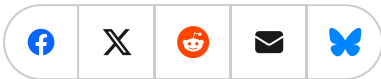
On the plus side, complaints from neighbors about residential noise dropped 20 percent on open streets during the same period (on non-open streets, such complaints dropped by only 8.4 percent). And as the pandemic receded, complaints about commercial noise rose at a lower rate than citywide.

Also good news: In 2024, the number of open streets rose for the first time since the height of the pandemic. DiNapoli attributed the rise to a 2023 program established by DOT that helped fund operations and management of public spaces through November 2026.

Can open streets do everything? Of course not. The pandemic decimated the New York City job market. By the end of 2020, foot traffic in key retail corridors in Manhattan was 50 percent below its 2019 level — and the open streets program certainly didn't erase all of that impact, as the chart below shows.



The number of open streets rose in 2024 — and DOT says there were even more in 2025. [Chart: NYS Comptroller](#)



Gersh Kuntzman

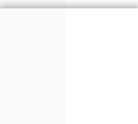
Tabloid legend Gersh Kuntzman has been with New York newspapers since 1989, including stints at the New York Daily News, the Post, the Brooklyn Paper and even a cup of coffee with the Times. He's also the writer and producer of "Murder at the Food Coop," which was a hit at the NYC Fringe Festival in 2016, and "SUV: The Musical" in 2007. He also writes the Cycle of Rage column, which is archived [here](#).

Read More: [CAR-FREE STREETS](#) | [DOT](#) | [ECONOMICS](#) | [GOVERNMENT ORGANIZATIONS](#) | [ISSUES & CAMPAIGNS](#) | [LOCAL BUSINESSES](#) | [OPEN STREETS](#) | [SMALL BUSINESSES](#)



Stay in touch

Sign up for our free newsletter



[SIGN UP](#)

Streetsblog has migrated to a new comment system. New commenters can register directly in the comments section of any article. Returning commenters: your previous comments and display name have been preserved, but you'll need to reclaim your account by clicking "Forgot your password?" on the sign-in form, entering your email, and following the verification link to set a new password — this is required because passwords could not be carried over during the migration. For questions, contact tips@streetsblog.org.

More from Streetsblog New York City

BUS LANES

A Better Busway Is Coming To Livingston Street In Downtown Brooklyn



Dave Colon September 22, 2026



STREETSBLOG EMPIRE STATE | BIKE INFRASTRUCTURE

Roundup: Local New York Jurisdictions Target the Wrong 'E-Bikes' as Market Outpaces State Law



Austin C. Jefferson September 22, 2026



PRESIDENT TRUMP'S SECOND TERM

Tuesday's Headlines: The President Was At Gracie Mansion Edition



Gersh Kuntzman September 22, 2026

SAFETY

City Exempted Truck in Fatal Crash from Life-Saving Safety Component



Sophia Lebowitz September 21, 2026

People-First Streets Will Pave The Way For The Best Version Of Downtown Brooklyn: Report



Dave Colon September 21, 2026

[See all posts](#) →

Covering the fight for sustainable cities

Sign up for our free newsletter

Email

SIGN UP



Streetsblog Basics

- About
- Calendar
- Contact Us
- Staff & Board
- Donate to/Sponsor
- Streetsblog
- Comment Moderation Policy
- ‘Field Guide to Micro Mobility’
- Job Listings



